EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

If God Knows, Are We Free?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 4:3-4

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 4 (Obedience and Disobedience, Compulsion and Justice), Chapters 3-4

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 18 November 2024, in person and on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: From Creation to Choice

We have established that there is **a Creator** (Essay 1), that this Creator is **who we call Hashem** (Essay 2), and that He **revealed His will**, the Torah (Essay 3). "Now we talk about our choices. The first time we're talking about humans."

Last week, in the introduction and Chapters 1-2 of Essay 4, Saadia argued that **the world was created for humans** and that humans are the most elevated creatures. Everyone agrees humans are the most elevated creatures **on earth**; whether the whole world was created for us was debated, "but it's not so relevant to the rest of this essay." All Saadia needed was that humans are the pinnacle, so **to them Hashem gave the Torah and the commandments, and they have free will**.

Chapters 3 to 6 are about free will itself, "all fascinating questions."

Saadia's absolute free will

Among the Rishonim there are different views of **how much** free will a human has. **Saadia is one of the most extreme**: he holds **complete and absolute free will**, stricter even than the Rambam. "For Saadia everything really is up to human beings."

This may be **a reaction to Islamic philosophy**. As Saadia told us in his introduction, he lived in a milieu with strong Islamic influence, and one dominant school there held **determinism**: God is in control and determines everything, and humans do not really have free will. "Saadia completely rejects that and goes to the other extreme."

Part 1: Chapter 3, Four Points on Free Will

Point 1: Hashem gives us the ability

Since Hashem gave us the Torah and revealed His will, it is fitting and just that He give us **the ability and the strength** to do what He commanded and refrain from what He forbade. This is

clear **rationally and scripturally**: **Hashem never commands what a person cannot do.**

- **Rationally:** God would never give someone a task he has no ability to perform or refrain from.
- **Scripturally: עמי מה עשיתי לך ומה הלאתיך? ענה בי**, "My people, what have I done to you, how have I wearied you? Answer Me" (Michah 6:3). Have I ever given you something you could not fulfil?

"This was a famous idea developed by many after him. **Rav Dessler** has a famous piece on how God never tests a person beyond what he can do. But this is **the origin** of the concept."

Point 2: The choice comes before the action

Free will must **precede** the action: a person must be fully able to choose to do or to refrain. Saadia rejects two alternatives:

The view	Saadia's verdict
Choice is **simultaneous** with the action: God determines the act, and our "choice" is our consent at the moment	Then choice and act are **mutually interdependent**, so it is **still determined**. Absurd
Choice comes **after** the action, letting us somehow withdraw from it	**Absurd.** "The action's done. How can my will change that?"

"This is only intelligible" against the background of **compromise schools within Islamic thought**. Unwilling to say that everything is determined, they tried to bring choice in alongside determinism. Saadia rejects both, as did essentially all the Rishonim, "although we will see one of the Rishonim, **Chasdai Crescas** in ***Or Hashem***, took a similar kind of approach" to the question of foreknowledge. The main thing, which all Jewish thinkers hold: **our free will comes before the action.**

Point 3: Not acting is also a choice

Another compromise held that we choose our actions, but **our abstentions are determined by Hashem**. Saadia says no: **choosing not to do something is also part of our free will.**

- **Human passivity is not like Hashem's.** Before Hashem created the world He was, "if we can use such terms," passive, and we do not say His passivity was a kind of activity. (We saw in Essay 1 that there is no "opposite" with Hashem.)
- **But with humans, not doing usually means doing the opposite.** If you don't favour something, you are normally against it. "It's rare to actually find a middle ground."
- Saadia's verses: **keep My mitzvot… and do not do the abominations**, and **they did no wrong; they walked in His ways** (Tehillim 119:3). Doing the mitzvot means not doing the abominations, and not doing wrong means walking in His way: opposites.

"Generally speaking, humans are black and white. I like that person, I don't like that person. I'm in a good mood, a bad mood. If you think about it deeply enough, normally human activities have an opposite."

The deeper point, as the Rabbi understood it: Hashem is **passive** towards our choices. If every passivity were really a hidden activity, then Hashem's passivity towards our actions would be a kind of activity in them, and **we would not have full free will**. So Saadia distinguishes: **our** passivity is a subtle kind of activity, so free will covers it; **Hashem's** passivity is complete, so it does not interfere at all.

Leo asked whether being passive is itself a decision. "That's the point. It's will." And Hashem not yet creating was not a will, since there was no conflict. Asked whether Hashem's passivity might still be "creative" in some way: "That's a precise point. **It's not.** If Hashem's passivity were active, then every time He passively allows us to choose, we still wouldn't have free will."

Point 4: What you did not choose is not your action

"An interesting point which has halachic consequences." **An action is yours only if you chose it.** Someone may object: the Torah punishes **mistakes**. Saadia: no, in those cases **you did choose the act**; you just lacked some knowledge.

- **The accidental killer** was **intentionally chopping wood**. He was not careful, but the chopping was his conscious act. That is why he must flee to the city of refuge.
- **Breaking Shabbat by mistake:** you were **intentionally** cutting wood; you just forgot it was Shabbat.

The Rabbi laid out the halachic categories, taking Shabbat:

Category	Example	Consequence
Mezid (deliberate)	You know it is Shabbat, know it is forbidden, and do it	The death penalty
Shogeg (inadvertent)	You **forget it is Shabbat**: you wake up thinking it is Sunday and water and plough your garden. Or you know it is Shabbat but **don't know watering is forbidden**. Either way, **the act itself is fully conscious**	A ***korban chatat*** in Temple times
Mit'asek (unaware of the act)	You **lean back against a wall** and switch on a light you didn't see. Or you carry outside an *eruv* **without knowing something is in your pocket**	**Nothing**, not even a korban. "It's not your action. I never chose to do that"

"Nowadays you should write down every time you do a *shogeg*, so when the Beit HaMikdash is rebuilt you bring a korban chatat for it." And: "Most of the time when people do something on Shabbat, it's *mit'asek*, by the way."

A participant asked the difference between not realising it is Shabbat and not realising you are carrying. "Huge difference." When you forget it is Shabbat, **the watering** is a fully conscious decision; you are not punished, but you bring a korban. When you carry unknowingly, **you never decided to carry**. "That's precisely the point of this chapter. It fits in beautifully."

Sleepwalking: if you were sleepwalking while cutting wood and the wood killed someone, you would not go to the city of refuge. A participant objected that anyone could then claim to have

been sleepwalking. "Of course. We're talking theoretically." In practice it depends on whether the person is believed.

Chapter 3 in four points: Hashem gives us the ability; the choice comes before the action; abstaining is a choice too; and only a chosen act is your act.

Part 2: Chapter 4, Four Proofs That We Are Free

Hashem gives us absolute free will and **compels us to nothing, good or bad**. Saadia's proofs come from four sources:

1. Sense: we feel it

Can I choose now to speak? Yes. Can I choose to stop? Yes. Nothing and no one tells us what to do. "I think we can all agree that we do feel, deep down, that we can choose what to do in life."

2. Logic: five arguments

#	Argument
1	**One act cannot have two agents.** In Essay 1, among the **thirteen theories of creation** (almost a year ago), Saadia rejected **dualism**, the Gnostic two gods, partly because one thing cannot come from two agents. If God compelled us, every human act would have two agents, God and the human
2	**Why command at all?** If it is all determined, commandments are pointless
3	**Why reward or punish** someone compelled to do good or bad?
4	**No difference between good and bad people.** If I hire one man to build my house and another to demolish my other house for renovation, **I pay both equally**: each did what I asked
5	**The wicked would have a perfect defence.** In the World to Come, anyone could say, "I had no ability to go against Your will," and he would be right

The Rabbi called the first **"probably the weakest."** A participant pointed out that dualism is about two gods creating, which is quite different from a human acting under compulsion. "Correct. Not great. You're 100% right. The other ones are much better." Arguments 3 to 5 are similar, "and obviously a strong proof."

3. Scripture

- **"Choose life."**
- To the sinners: **this came from your own hand**. It is not My fault.
- **The false prophets**: Hashem says, I am not responsible for them; they chose to be false.

"Over and over again you see in Scripture God saying: it's not Me, it's you who chose this."

4. Tradition

"A side point: I don't know if you've noticed, **Saadia rarely quotes Chazal**." The Rabbi could find only two places before this in the book. The central role of Chazal "became much stronger in the time of the Rishonim; the Geonim didn't have that relationship yet with the Talmud."

הכל בידי שמים חוץ מיראת שמים

Everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven. (Berachot 33b)

Whether you become ill is in the hands of Heaven ("although if you go out without your coat, you're responsible"). The fear of Heaven is up to you, as the verse says: **what does Hashem your God ask of you, but to fear Him?**

Three literary devices

Even though all this is clear, the Torah drives it home in **three ways**:

1. **A question: החפץ אחפץ מות רשע?** "Do I desire the death of the wicked?" (Yechezkel 18:23)
2. **An assertion:** I do not desire it; I want him **to return** and live.
3. **An oath: חי אני... אם אחפץ במות הרשע**, "As I live... I do not desire the death of the wicked" (Yechezkel 33:11).

The first half of Essay 4: humans are the pinnacle (Chapters 1-2); free will is complete, comes before the act, covers abstaining, and only chosen acts count (Chapter 3); and it is proven by sense, logic, Scripture and tradition (Chapter 4). "Now we have lots of questions to ask on free will." The rest of Chapter 4 and Chapters 5-6 are questions and answers.

Part 3: Why Does Hashem Allow Evil?

Saadia asks three questions here, "in truth only two, because two and three are basically the same."

Question 1. If everything were determined, evil would simply be God's will. But now that **humans are completely free** and do evil, **God tolerates it**. If He is all-powerful and all-good, **why doesn't He stop it?**

Saadia: **humans** push away things they dislike, because those things bother them. If something bothers you and you can stop it, it would be strange not to. But **Hashem is not affected by anything**. As we learned in Essay 2 on anthropomorphism, when Hashem says **"I hate sin"**, He does not hate anything; it makes no difference to Him. He tells us not to sin **because it is bad for us**. Wronging others harms our own souls.

האתי הם מכעיסים נאם ה׳? הלוא אתם

Is it Me they anger, says Hashem? Is it not themselves? (Yirmiyahu 7:19)

So evil **looks** bad from our perspective, but it is not bad for Hashem. He told us not to do it, for our good, and He tolerates it because it makes no difference to Him.

Part 4: Foreknowledge and Free Will

"Now I want you just to appreciate: **Saadia is the very first Jewish thinker recorded who asked this question**," which would occupy the Rishonim for the next three to four hundred years.

The dilemma

- If we choose freely, **Hashem does not know** what we will choose, and **His knowledge is limited**. That makes Him imperfect, which is unacceptable.
- If Hashem **does know** what we will choose, since He knows everything, then it is not possible for us to do otherwise, and **we have no free will**.

Saadia: "simpler than the question before"

"For Saadia it's unbelievable. Look what he says." **The answer is one line:**

There is no proof that Hashem's knowing something causes it. Whoever thinks so is either mistaken or making it up.

His proof: **if whatever Hashem knew were caused by His knowing it, everything would have existed from the very beginning**, since He knew everything from the beginning. There would be no such thing as anything coming into being. Rather, **He knows things as they are**: what will be made, He knows will be made, and **what a person will choose, He knows the person will choose**.

Question 3: can I keep quiet at seven o'clock?

If Hashem knows I will speak at 7 o'clock this evening, do I have the ability to keep quiet at 7 o'clock?

Saadia: **if I were going to keep quiet, then from the beginning we would have said that Hashem knew I would keep quiet.** "This is the key line." Hashem knows **the end result**: what the person will finally decide **after all his thoughts, his deliberation, his delaying, his going forwards and backwards**.

The alarm clock

Your alarm goes off at 6 o'clock. "I'm going to be late for work. Give it one more minute. Should I get up? Okay, one more minute." At 6.05 it rings again. At 6.06 you get up. **Hashem knows you will get up at 6.06 and three seconds.** He hasn't caused it. **You chose.** He just knows that after all your deliberating, that is what you will choose.

The Kuzari agrees

The **Kuzari** (Essay 5, Chapter 20) takes the same approach: **knowledge of something is not its cause**, just as **knowing something that has already happened** does not cause it. "I know everything you've done in your life. I haven't caused it." So too knowledge of the future. **Rav Yosef Albo** also took this approach.

Part 5: The Class Wrestles with It

Johnny and the sweets

Flora offered the analogy she uses with A-level students: a mother gives Johnny a pound to buy sugar and milk, knowing in her heart that he will sneak in some sweets as well.

"That's a different theory. That's **Chasdai Crescas**, a very deterministic view." The mother knows **because she knows his nature**, so he could not have chosen otherwise. Saadia says

something different: Hashem knows **the choice**. Johnny will reach the shop, think "what if my mum catches me, what if she doesn't," and he has the choice, and Hashem knows that **after all his deliberation** he will choose the sweets. "Not that I know his nature and that he likes sweets. I know he's going to buy sweets **because I know that's what he's going to choose**."

Eve recalled an image she had heard, perhaps from Rabbi Sacks: **a shepherd on a hill** watching which sheep go through; he sees it but does not cause it. **Richard** summed up: we only know the past and draw conclusions about the future, but **Hashem has knowledge of our conclusion**, whatever thought process we go through. "Correct. Precisely. He doesn't have to work it out."

"Am I just following the script?"

Doron objected: I accept that knowing my past doesn't mean you caused it. But if you know my one future path, **I'm simply an actor following the script**. It would be different if Hashem knew all the branching possibilities (if you choose X it leads to Y), rather than the single path I will take.

The Rabbi polled the room. **Philippe**: it makes sense. **Maria**: "not my favourite, but I can wrap my head around it." **Eve**: "I suppose it does."

Asked whether Hashem follows non-Jews too: "A really big question." On the Rambam's approach, whether Hashem is involved depends on whether the person **wants a relationship with Him**, Jew or non-Jew. "But that's a whole different discussion."

The Rabbi's own difficulty

"The problem with this approach is exactly what you're saying." Next time you face a big choice, at the back of your mind: **it's been decided**. A participant asked whether it also brings back the problem of reward and punishment.

And the Rabbi added a problem of his own:

"If Hashem knows exactly what I will choose for the next 120 years from the moment I'm born, **what's the point of living?** He could create me, you, Richard, Doron, Leo, run us through His 'program', see that this one gets 60%, that one 70% or 80%, and give us our reward. Finished. You don't need a world. **It's one of the biggest problems I've had with this approach for many, many years.**"

Saadia does slightly address this in the next chapter: **you have to live it**, to go through the process of choosing. A participant suggested the purpose is **to experience** it. "Okay, just give us that experience." We know why Hashem created the world, that we **acquire goodness for ourselves** by choosing. But He could give us the experience of the choices we would have made. "Why create me?"

The discussion continued after the recording stopped.

Summary

1. **Saadia's free will is absolute**, perhaps a reaction to Islamic determinism.
2. **Chapter 3:** Hashem never commands the impossible; the choice **precedes** the act (not simultaneous, not after); **abstaining is a choice too**, while Hashem's passivity is complete

and does not interfere; and **only a chosen act is yours**, as the halachic categories *mezid*, *shogeg* and *mit'asek* show.

3. **Chapter 4, proofs:** sense, five logical arguments (the strongest: why command, why reward, the builder and demolisher paid alike, the wicked man's perfect defence), Scripture, and Chazal: "everything is in the hands of Heaven except the fear of Heaven." Hashem says it by question, assertion and oath.
4. **Why evil?** Sin does not affect Hashem; He forbids it for our sake. "Is it Me they anger?"
5. **Foreknowledge:** Saadia is the first to ask it. **Knowing is not causing.** Hashem knows the conclusion of our deliberation (the alarm at 6.06), as the Kuzari also says. The class pressed hard, and the Rabbi shared his own difficulty: **if He knows, why live it out?**

Coming Up

- **Next week:** the other approaches of the Rishonim to foreknowledge: **the Rambam, the Ralbag, Chasdai Crescas**, with side points from **the Ra'avad** and **Rabbeinu Bachya in Chovot HaLevavot**.

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